

# >> **boosting** the burn

You're exercising hard and avoiding foods with high sugar and fat content, but somehow you're not losing the weight you want.

The problem could be your metabolism. There are aspects of your metabolism that you can influence, so now is the time to work on those.

Metabolism refers to the chemical processes that go on in every cell of our body, enabling us to live and function. Controlled by our hormones and nervous system, metabolism keeps everything working as it should.

None of those chemical processes can take place without energy, and your body gets that, in the form of calories, from the food you eat.

Your Basal Metabolic Rate (BMR; see pp.98–99) is the number of calories your body needs to sustain itself and to function—even when you're sleeping. You also need calories for all your physical activity, whether that's brushing your teeth or training for the Olympics. The bottom line is, if you want to lose weight, you must burn more calories than you take in (eat).

## **Burning more, burning less**

Some of the factors that govern your BMR, such as your sex and age, are out of your control. If you're a man, your body needs more calories a day than if you are a woman. As you get older, your metabolism naturally slows down and uses fewer calories.

If you want to lose weight, you should target those factors you can control. One is your level of physical activity—more exercise burns more calories. The other is your lean-muscle-to-fat ratio. As it turns out, the two are linked. The more you exercise—particularly if you exercise in specific ways (see p.177)—the more lean muscle you'll build, and having a high lean-muscle-to-fat ratio means you'll burn more calories (see p.99). So it's a win-win situation.

## >> **boost the burn** unusual facts

- **Too hot? Too cold?** If the ambient temperature is very low or very high, the body has to work harder to maintain its normal body temperature. Naturally enough, this increases your BMR.
- **Stand up for fitness.** Standing uses more energy than sitting, so next time you're standing on the bus, think of it as a mini-workout and enjoy it.
- **Time your eating.** Your metabolism is higher straight after exercise, so if you eat immediately after working out, you will burn more of those calories.
- **Fidgeting pays off.** An American study found that fidgeting produces “non exercise activity thermogenesis.” In other words, it burns calories. People in the study with more body fat burned 350 calories less per day than those who were leaner. The leaner people fidgeted more and were generally more active.
- **The male advantage.** Men generally have faster metabolisms than women because they tend to be larger and have less body fat.